

Sarada Sriram: The Visionary Behind India's Largest Women-Led Learning Movement

In a candid conversation with *Business Today*, Sarada Sriram discusses her pathbreaking journey with Ideal Play Abacus India and how her work has created a nationwide ecosystem for women entrepreneurs and child development.



Sarada Sriram
Chief Executive Officer
Ideal Play Abacus India Pvt Ltd

inspired by her father who had been an entrepreneur from early in his career. She founded Ideal Play Abacus India (IPA) in 2003.

The company obtained its ISO 9001:2000 certification and is affiliated with Play Abacus Malaysia and the Guang Xi Abacus Association, China. In a short span, the company established over 1,000 centres across India with more than 2,000 trained teachers, and serves over 70,000 students. IPA has also recently expanded internationally, opening centres in countries such as the USA, UAE, and Australia.

At the Franchise Awards 2006 event in Delhi, Sarada Sriram won the prestigious "Best Woman Entrepreneur of the Year" award given by Franchise India and Euro Kids. IPA also offers various programs such as Vedic Maths, Amazing Memory (in association with Dr. Yip, World Adult

Memory Champion) for children aged 12 years and above, and a handwriting program for children aged 5 and above. It additionally runs Creative Art India, an online international art program, along with two new English programs – Phonics Star and the Brite English Program. IPA has also recently launched a chain of preschools called Arka Kids.

More than being caught up in the race for size, turnover, and scale, Sarada views her business as a transformative force for Indian womanhood. In this sense, her work can be seen as social entrepreneurship. Countless women across India have found new opportunities by taking up IPA franchises and training as teachers. These women, in turn, are shaping the lives of thousands of young children. This, Sarada believes, is the company's greatest achievement.

Sarada Sriram has always been a brilliant student who believed in all-round development. She stood second in Tamil Nadu in the 12th standard board examination. She was awarded the gold medal in the B.Com degree course at Stella Maris College, Madras, and was also recognized as the Best Outgoing Student in 1991. She is an ICWA gold medalist and secured the 10th rank All India in the Chartered Accountancy examination. A talented dancer and trained classical singer, Sarada represented India in the cultural segment of the Commonwealth Games closing ceremony in New Zealand in 1990.

Sarada began her career with the Unit Trust of India as a funds manager, and later quit to set up her own business,

